UX Research

Your constantly-updated definition of UX Research and collection of videos and articles

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What is UX Research?

UX (user experience) research is the systematic study of target users and their requirements, to add realistic contexts and insights to design processes. UX researchers adopt various methods to uncover problems and design opportunities. Doing so, they reveal valuable information which can be fed into the design process.

See why UX research is a critical part of the UX design process.

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UX Research is about Finding Insights to Guide Successful Designs

When you do UX research, you'll be better able to give users the best solutions—because you can discover *exactly* what they need. You can apply UX research at *any* stage of the design process. UX researchers often begin with **qualitative measures, to determine users' motivations and needs**. Later, they might **use quantitative measures to test their results**. To do UX research well, you must take a **structured approach when you gather data** from your users. It's vital to use methods that 1) are *right* for the purpose of your research and 2) will give you the *clearest* information. Then, you can **interpret your findings so you can build valuable insights into your design**.

> *"I get very uncomfortable when someone makes a design decision without customer contact."*
>
> *– Dan Ritzenthaler, Senior Product Designer at HubSpot*

We can divide UX research into two subsets:

1. **Qualitative research** – Using methods such as interviews and ethnographic field studies, you work to get an in-depth understanding of **why** users do what they do (e.g., why they missed a call to action, why they feel how they do about a website). For example, you can do user interviews with a small number of users and ask open-ended questions to get personal insights into their exercise habits. Another aspect of qualitative research is usability testing, to monitor (e.g.) users' stress responses. You should do qualitative research

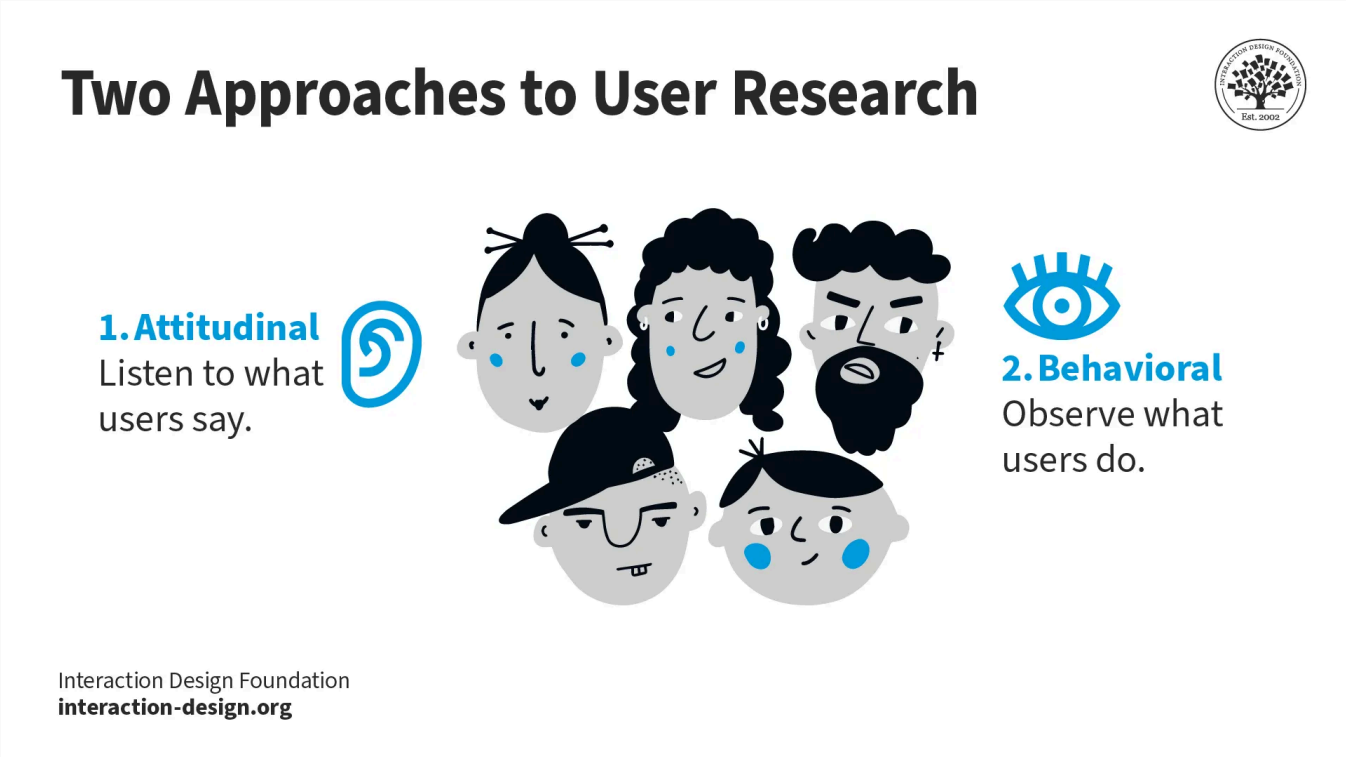
carefully. As it involves collecting non-numerical data (e.g., opinions, motivations), there's a risk that your personal opinions will influence findings.

2. **Quantitative research** – Using more-structured methods (e.g., surveys, analytics), you gather measurable data about **what** users do and test assumptions you drew from qualitative research. For example, you can give users an online survey to answer questions about their exercise habits (e.g., "How many hours do you work out per week?"). With this data, you can discover patterns among a large user group. If you have a large enough sample of representative test users, you'll have a more statistically reliable way of assessing the population of target users. Whatever the method, with careful research design you can gather objective data that's unbiased by your presence, personality or assumptions. However, quantitative data alone can't reveal deeper human insights.

We can additionally divide UX research into two approaches:

1. **Attitudinal** – you listen to what users say—e.g., in interviews.
2. **Behavioral** – you see what users do through observational studies.

When you use a mix of both quantitative and qualitative research as well as a mix of attitudinal and behavioral approaches, you can usually get the clearest view of a design problem.



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Use UX Research Methods *throughout* Development

The Nielsen Norman Group—an industry-leading UX consulting organization—identifies **appropriate UX research methods** which you can use during a project's **four stages**. Key methods are:

1. **Discover – Determine what is *relevant* for users.**

- Contextual inquiries – Interview suitable users in *their own environment* to see how they perform the task/s in question.
- Diary studies – Have users record their daily interactions with a design or log their performance of activities.

2. **Explore – Examine how to address all users' needs.**

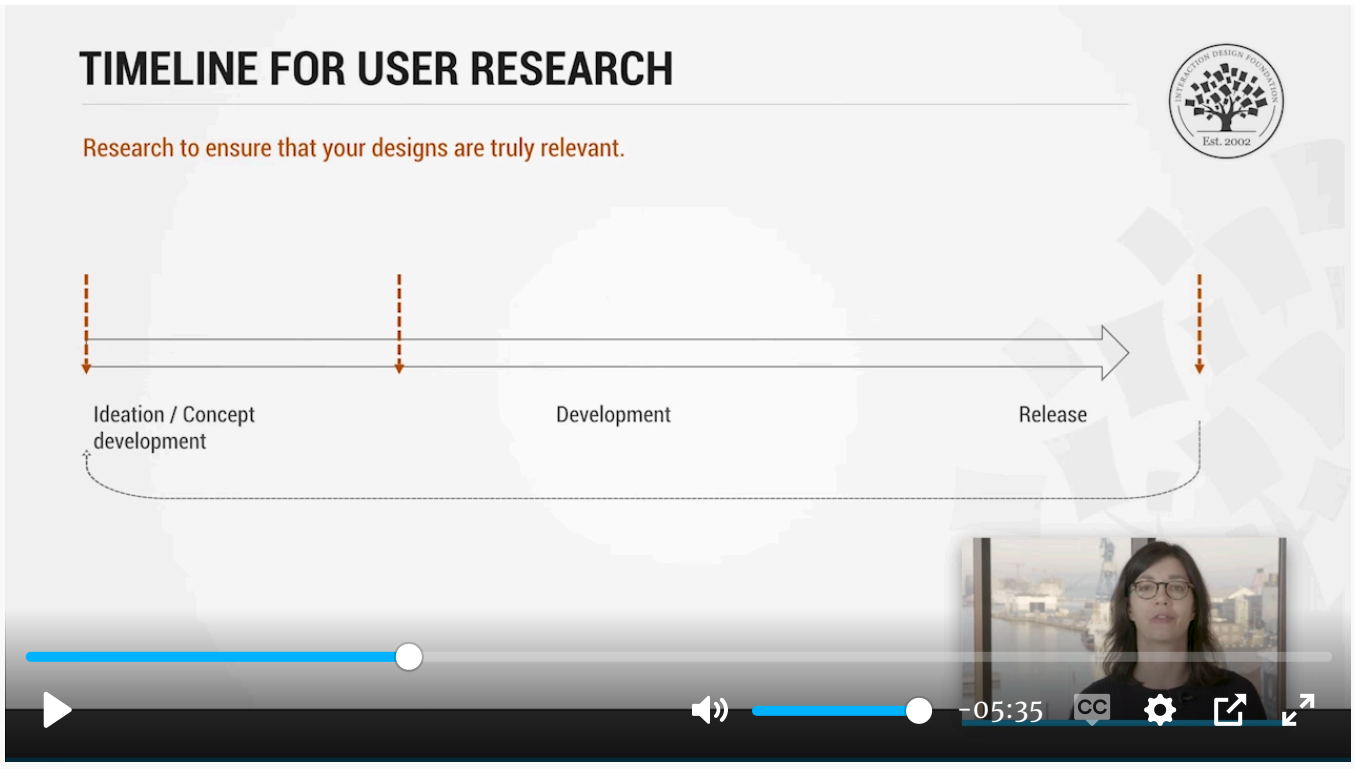
- Card sorting – Write words and phrases on cards; then let participants organize them in the most meaningful way and label categories to ensure that your design is structured in a logical way.
- Customer journey maps – Create user journeys to expose potential pitfalls and crucial moments.

3. **Test – Evaluate your designs.**

- Usability testing – Ensure your design is easy to use.
- Accessibility evaluations – Test your design to ensure it's accessible to everyone.

4. **Listen – Put issues in perspective, find any new problems and notice trends.**

- Surveys/Questionnaires – Use these to track how users' feel about your product.
- Analytics – Collect analytics/metrics to chart (e.g.) website traffic and build reports.



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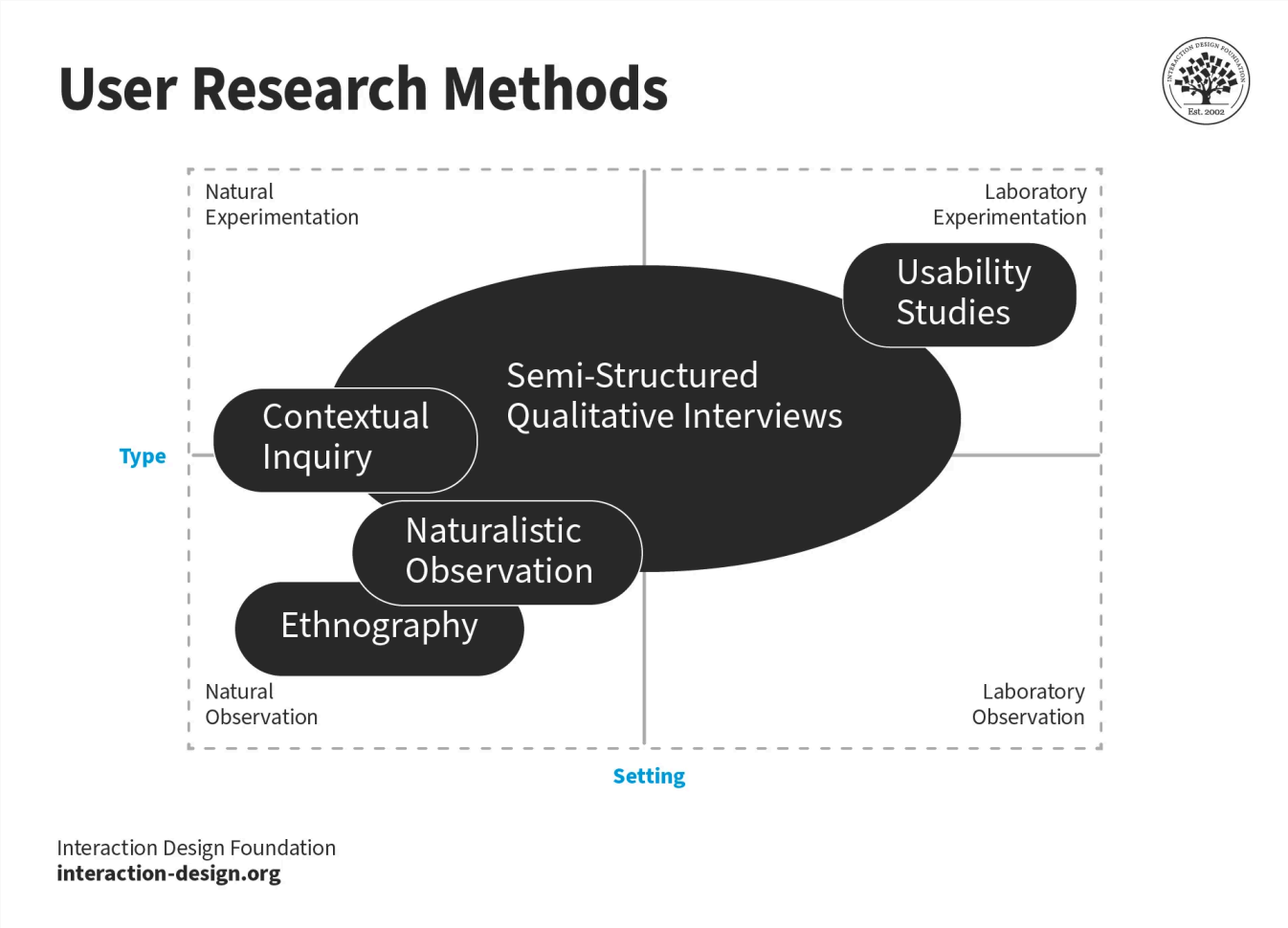
Whichever UX research method you choose, you need to **consider the pros and cons of the different techniques**. For instance, card sorting is cheap and easy, but you may find it time-consuming when it comes to analysis. Also, it might not give you in-depth contextual meaning. Another constraint is your **available resources**, which will dictate when, how much and which type of UX research you can do. So, **decide carefully on the most relevant method/s for *your* research**. Moreover, **involve stakeholders from your organization *early on***. They can reveal valuable UX insights and help keep your research in line with business goals. Remember, a design team values UX research as a way to ***validate* its assumptions about users in the field**, ***slash* the cost of the best deliverables** and ***keep* products in high demand**—ahead of competitors'.



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User research methods have different pros and cons,and vary from observations of users in context to controlled experiments in lab settings.

Learn More about UX Research

For a thorough grasp of UX research, take our course here:
[User Research – Methods and Best Practices]

Read an extensive range of UX research considerations, discussed in *Smashing* Magazine:
[A Comprehensive Guide To UX Research]

See the Nielsen Norman Group's list of UX research tips:
[UX Research Cheat Sheet]

Here's a handy, example-rich catalog of UX research tools:
[43 UX research tools for optimizing your product]

Questions related to UX Research

- Is UX research a good career?
- How much does a UX researcher earn?
- UX research vs UX design: What's the difference?
- Is there a difference between UX research and user research?
- What are UX research methods?
- Do you need a degree to become a UX researcher?
- What is the UX research process?
- What are the UX research tools?
- How can you build a UX research case study?
- Will AI replace UX research?
- How to conduct UX research in agile teams?
- Why is UX research important?

Literature on UX Research

Here's the entire UX literature on **UX Research** by the Interaction Design Foundation, collated in one place:

Featured article

15 Guiding Principles for UX Researchers

We've found that a lot of first time UX researchers have similar questions and concerns when they start working in UX design. So, we thought we'd round up and tackle some of the most common questions to form a set of useful principles for UX researchers. Of course, this isn't a complete guide to UX research (there are some fairly weighty tomes out there which do that) but it's a good starting place to answer some of those nagging UX questions.

Show full article

Learn more about UX Research

Take a deep dive into UX Research with our course User Research – Methods and Best Practices .

How do you plan to design a product or service that your users will *love*, if you don't know what they *want* in the first place? As a user experience designer, you shouldn't leave it to chance to design something outstanding; you should make the effort to understand your users and build on that knowledge from the outset. User research is the way to do this, and it can therefore be thought of as **the largest part of user experience design**.

In fact, user research is often the first step of a UX design process—after all, **you cannot begin to design a product or service without first understanding what your users want!** As you gain the skills required, and learn about the best practices in user research, you'll get first-hand knowledge of your users and be able to **design the optimal product—one that's truly relevant for your users and, subsequently, outperforms your competitors'**.

This course will give you insights into the most essential qualitative research methods around and will teach you how to put them into practice in your design work. You'll also have the opportunity to embark on **three practical projects where you can apply what you've learned to carry out user research in the real world**. You'll learn details about how to plan user research projects and fit them into your own work processes in a way that maximizes the impact your research can have on your designs. On top of that, you'll gain practice with different methods that will help you analyze the results of your research and communicate your findings to your clients and stakeholders —workshops, user journeys and personas, just to name a few!

By the end of the course, you'll have not only a Course Certificate but also three case studies to add to your portfolio. And remember, a portfolio with engaging case studies is invaluable if you are looking to break into a career in UX design or user research!

We believe you should learn from the best, so we've gathered a team of experts to help teach this course alongside our own course instructors. That means you'll meet a new instructor in each of the lessons on research methods who is an expert in their field—we hope you enjoy what they have in store for you!

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